

Burning (CD-)ROM

Agent 001 burns for a CD-Writer

Low Disk Space! Not a great message to see one fine Sunday morning. I had planned to spend the day tinkering with my computer, and had begun copying some MP3 CDs I had borrowed from a friend the day before. I constantly swap MP3s, freeware and other stuff that I download with my friends—thanks largely, to my always on cable connection. The low disk space error was the last straw. I decided to change my plans, and finally get that CD-Writer I had been planning to buy for some time now.

My old 32X CD-ROM drive had outlived its usefulness and was also giving me a lot of read errors. With a new CD-Writer, I could free up a lot of hard disk space, by archiving the GBs of MP3s, movies and freeware I had stored.

After a quick trip to the ATM, I visited my local hardware guy to check out what models were available. My requirements were simple—I needed an internal IDE CD-Writing device that was fast and cheap, made by a reputed brand and one that included the latest burning software. I was hoping the local *hard-warewallah* would guide me to the best model available. Easier said than done! I discovered that there are tons of options to choose from—there was LG, Samsung, Plextor, Yamaha, Iomega, Sony, BenQ, ASUS, and quite a few others I had never even heard of. Speeds ranged from the latest 52X to the older 32X write speeds. Devices that could

write at 48X were the most popular. All of them included the audio cable, and most had the interface cable and Nero Burning ROM as the bundled software. Samsung even had a combo CD-RW/DVD-ROM drive that really got me interested. Not only would I be able to burn CDs, I would also be able to play the DVD movies that some of my friends had! I decided to explore further and—as the TV commercials say—to make sure I got the ‘best deal’.

I headed out to the hardware-*mandi* of Mumbai, Lamington Road, and asked a couple of vendors about the options. I discovered that at close to Rs 3,000, the Samsung 48X CD-Writer was the cheapest, while the Plextor 48X was one of the most expensive at about Rs 6,500. The Sony 52X was available for Rs 4,100. One of the dealers here recommended the LG 52X drive, priced at Rs 3,350. The Samsung 48X combo drive was available at Rs 4,800, but the dealer advised me against it, as it hadn’t got a good customer feedback. Instead, he suggested that I buy either a plain vanilla Samsung or LG one, and opt for a separate DVD ROM drive, as the total price would approximately work

out to be the same. When I asked him about other brands such as ASUS, HP and Yamaha, I was told that these had not been well-appreciated either. More confused than ever, I decided to take a break.

After a lot of thought over a cold drink, I called up a friend and got the number of his dealer in Andheri, a suburb of Mumbai. I was in for a shock—the prices this dealer quoted were significantly higher than the Lamington Road dealers. It

seems that location matters a lot, with dealers in areas such as Andheri, Bandra and Khar quoting higher prices. For instance, the Sony 52X CD-Writer costs Rs 5,000 in Andheri, as compared to Rs 4,100 at Lamington Road. Similarly, the LG 48X drive costs Rs 3,800 in Andheri, as opposed to Rs 3,350 you can get it for at Lamington Road.

I went back to the Lamington Road dealer, and though he did not seem happy to see me again, he patiently answered my questions about the media. On enquiring, I discovered that 52X compatible blank media were simply unavailable and 48X was the best that could be obtained. Thus, buying a 52X CD-Writer would not really help as it would be slowed by the blank media I used. Following the motto of better safe than sorry, I dropped my plans for the combo drive and chose to buy a vanilla CD-Writer.

I decided on the LG 52X/24X/52X drive, under the assumption that the 52X compatible blank media should be available soon. Then I would really be able to churn out CDs faster than you could say “Burn baby Burn!” Meanwhile I will have to settle for the burn speed of the 48X, and the 6 GB of hard disk space I just freed up. ■

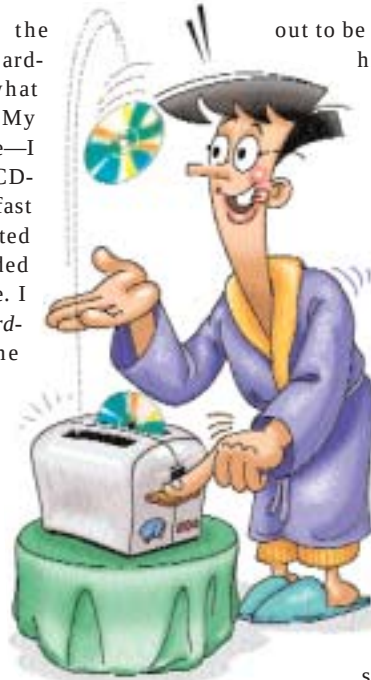


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar



- In contrast to spin speed, lower access times are better. Access time is more important if you are planning on running titles where the information you’re seeking is scattered and not sequential. This information can be obtained from the manual of the drive.
- The CD-Writer should support over-sizing and over-burning, as well as technologies such as Burn Proof.
- The writer must support TAO, DAO, and Multi-Session and Incremental Packet writing for CD-RW.
- Choose a writer that has support for RAW Writing.
- See to it that the drives have the required bundled software. Check if the drive is bundled with DOS and Win 3.x drivers.
- The higher the speed, the better a CD-RW will be able to perform, because the computer will transfer information to the drive more quickly. Note that compatible media must be used to take advantage of this.
- Confirm that the audio cables and other cables such as IDE cables come with the drive.
- The warranty period for the CD-Writer should be at least one year.